



Enviably record: Park Hang-seo (left) became one of the most successful coaches in Vietnam's football history, winning the 2019 and 2021 SEA Games with the under-23 side and the AFF Championship (2018) with the senior team. GETTY IMAGES

2018 Asian Cup, clinched consecutive AFF (ASEAN Football Federation) Championship titles (2022, 2023), and won consecutive gold medals at the Southeast Asian Games (2019, 2021).

Meanwhile, the senior team won the AFF Championship once (in 2018) and finished as runner-up in the tournament in 2022.

Vietnam's domestic league is valued at over INR 100 crores less than the ISL, at INR 367 crores. Additionally, its reliance on foreign players is much lower than India's, approximately 26 per cent.

The secret to its success lies in the Memorandum of Understanding with Japan, signed in 2014, and its reliance on South Korean coaches who have first-hand knowledge of how the game is played in this part of the world.

Over the past decade, former J1 League (Japan's top flight) side Vissel

Kobe coach Miura Toshiya has managed Vietnam's U23 and the senior national team.

Moreover, Japanese football experts like Tanabe Kazuyoshi have worked as the executive director of the V. League, while Yusuke Adachi and Takeshi Koshida have served as technical directors of the Vietnam Football Federation.

Coaching the South Korean way

According to the study, 'Coach Leadership Style and Korean Professional Soccer Team Performance: Collective Efficacy as a Mediator', the transformational and authentic leadership of head coaches had a positive effect on team performance.

Park Hang-seo, a former head coach in the K1 League (with Sangju Sangmu) and of the South Korean under-23 team, became one of the

most successful coaches in Vietnam's football history, winning the 2019 and 2021 SEA Games with the under-23 side and the AFF Championship (2018) with the senior team.

Hang-seo, who left the Vietnam job in January 2023, was also one of the candidates in contention for the Indian national team's head coach position before Marquez filled the role.

Hang-seo was not the only South Korean coach to attract attention.

Former South Korean international Shin Tae-yong guided Indonesia into the knockouts of the AFC Asian Cup 2023 for the first time and reached the final of the AFF Championship 2020, having taken over the team earlier that year.

With the under-23 side, he won a silver medal in the AFF U-23 Championship and a bronze medal at the SEA Games in 2021.

Meanwhile, compatriot Kim Pan-gon helped Malaysia qualify for the AFC Asian Cup on merit after 42 years, taking charge of the side in 2022. He also led Malaysia to a draw against South Korea, earning the team its first point in the tournament since 1980.

Such has been the demand for South Korean coaches that when Vietnam grew frustrated with French head coach Philippe Troussier, it turned to another South Korean, Kim Sang-sik, to find its footing again.

A lesson from Asia's elite

Australia and Uzbekistan are the only two nations in Asia's top 10 whose top-tier league market values are relatively close to India's league valuation.

However, both countries have made their respective marks on the international stage in different ways.

The Socceroos are known for

« The ISL may no longer aspire to be an IPL-style competition but can still drive Indian football development »